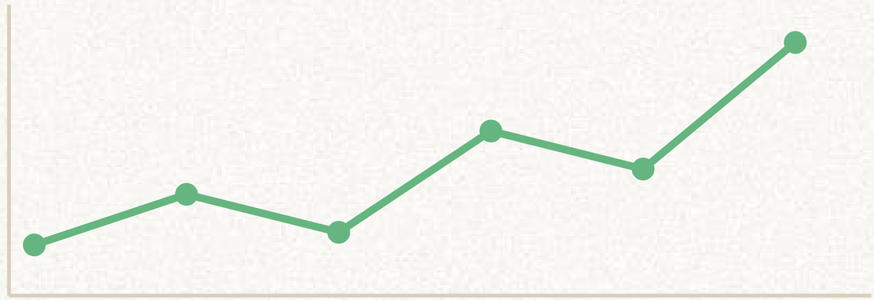
Lesson 1 · Writing

Understanding line graphs .

What line graphs are, how to read them, and what IELTS Writing Task 1 asks you to do with them.



LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to:

01 Identify the key parts of a line graph.

02 Recognise the difference between single and multiple line graphs.

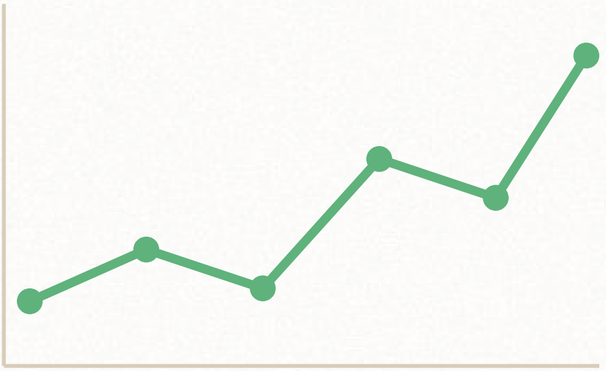
03 Explain what IELTS Writing Task 1 asks you to do.

04 Identify the key features to include in your answer.

ORANGE
ENGLISH

WHAT IS A LINE GRAPH?

A line graph shows how something changes over time, plotted as a continuous line.



It's one of the **most common chart types** in IELTS Writing Task 1.

TYPES OF LINE GRAPHS

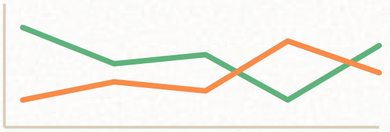
Single or multiple, read them differently.



Single line

Tracks one category over time, no comparison needed. Focus on the **shape and stages** of the trend.

"rose steadily, then plateaued, before climbing sharply"



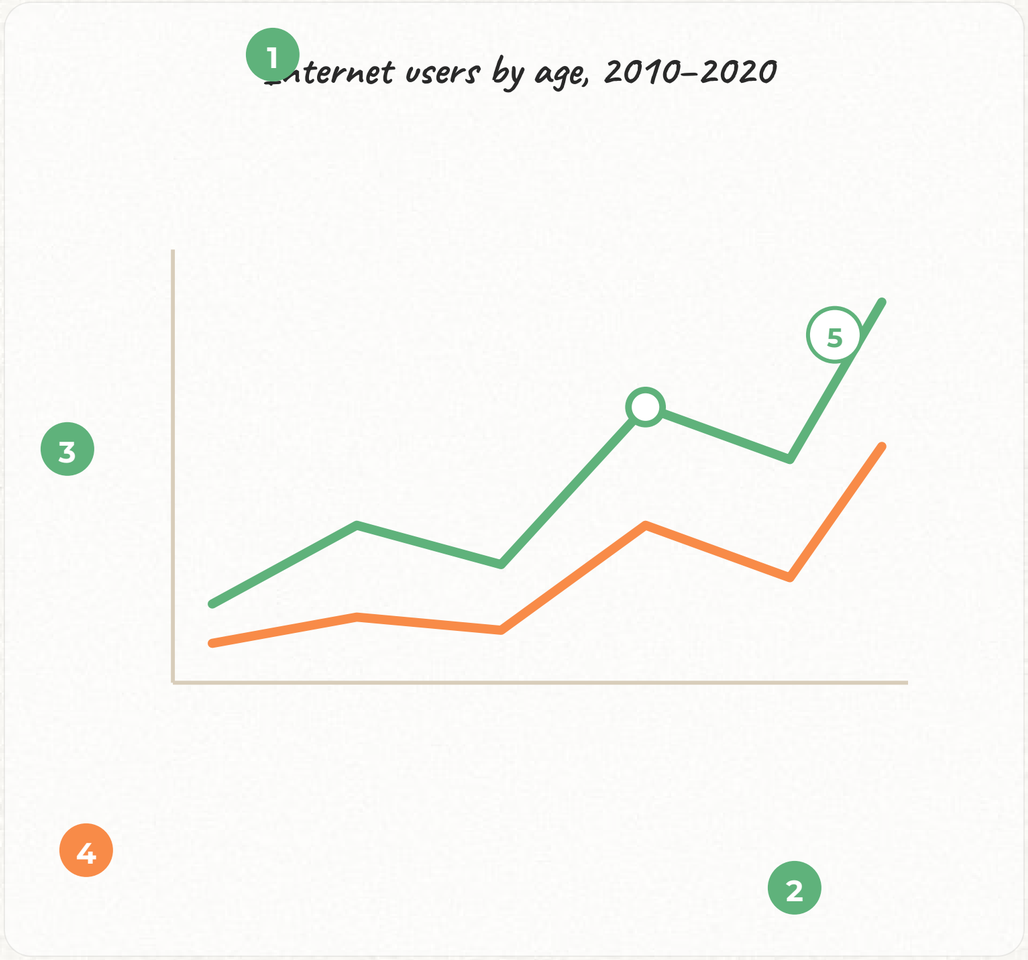
Multiple lines

Several trends to compare. Focus on **similarities, differences,** and the **crossover points** between lines.

"tea sales overtook coffee sales in 2015"

PARTS OF A LINE GRAPH

Know every part before you write.



examiner mode

1. **Title**, what's being measured.
2. **X-axis**, the time period.
3. **Y-axis**, the quantity measured, plus units (%, kg, millions).
4. **Legend**, which line is which.
5. **Data point**, the exact value at a given time.

reminder Always include **units** when describing values.

WHAT TASK 1 ASKS YOU TO DO

The instruction always asks three things:

follow the 3 steps →

01

Select

Choose the **most important** features. Don't describe everything.

02

Describe

Report the data **accurately**, with the right units.

03

Compare

Show how the lines **relate** to each other.

common mistake, repeating numbers

WEAK

The number went up a lot.

Lots of people used it.

STRONGER

The number **increased sharply**.

A **large proportion** used it.

KEY FEATURES TO NOTICE

Before you write, look for these five things.

01 **Overall trend**

Is it going up, down, or staying stable?

02 **Start and end points**

Where each line begins and finishes.

03 **Significant changes**

Sharp rises or sudden falls.

04 **Peaks and troughs**

The highest and lowest points.

05 **Comparisons**

Which line is highest, or whether lines cross.

ACTIVITY *your turn!*

Match each term to its definition.

Drag each term on the left to the meaning it belongs with on the right.

Title	What's being measured, the heading of the graph.
X-axis	The time period running along the bottom.
Y-axis	The quantity measured, running up the side.
Legend	The key showing which line is which.
Data points	The exact values plotted on each line.
Units	How values are counted, %, kg, millions.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

What to carry into your writing.

- A line graph shows **change over time**, check the title, axes, and units first.
- Graphs can be **single or multiple**, read each kind differently.
- Task 1 asks you to **select, describe, and compare**, not describe everything.
- Look for the **overall trend, start/end points, peaks, troughs,** and comparisons.

next up →
Vocabulary for Trends